



TWELVE-MONTH PROGRESS REPORT

South Africa: progress report, 2025-08-01 to 2026-08-23

Edition of 2026-08-23-2 · 145 systems and instruments tracked, 23 of them not held

Compiled 2026-08-23 from the Data Landscapers source base. Sections follow the status report. Each opens with a movement ledger comparing the position at the start and end of the period, which runs to the date of issue rather than to the last month's close.

Of 145 systems and instruments on this place's ledger, 70 changed position between 2025-08-01 and 2026-08-23, 8 did not, 43 carry no stated baseline, and 23 are **Not held** at both ends.

Shape check, run before the comparison: 594 sources for this place in the window — 60 in the earlier half (2025-08 to 2026-01), 534 in the later (2026-02 to 2026-08). The earlier half of the window is thin: this is a shorter comparison wearing a longer label, and the movement below rests mostly on the later half.

Movement values. *Advanced* — a system entered service, a stage was completed or an instrument was made. *Stalled* — a stated target passed without delivery. *Regressed* — an instrument was withdrawn or neutralised, or a measured position worsened. *Closed* — the programme ended. *No change* — the position at both ends is the same. *Baseline not held* — the base carries no position at the start of the period, so no movement can be stated. A value may carry a qualifying clause after a comma, as in *Advanced, slipped*.

Summary of the period

The largest measurable delivery of the twelve months was administrative. Smart identity documents through bank branches went from 30 branches across five banks in August 2025 to [296 branches and more than 385,000 applications in four months](#) by July 2026, and the 1,000-branch target originally set for 2029 was pulled forward to 750 by end-2026.

Against that, three instruments went backwards. The draft national artificial-intelligence policy was [withdrawn in April 2026](#) after fabricated references were found in it. The ministerial policy direction of 11 December 2025 intended to unblock satellite licensing was [rejected by the regulator in May 2026](#). SA Connect phase two was [declared ended in the February 2026 Budget Review](#) rather than completed, against a 2022 cabinet target of universal access in 36 months.

Most stated delivery dates in the period moved.

Infrastructure

Connectivity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Cape Town internet exchange (CINX)	Baseline not held	Present at six data-centre locations after going live at two further sites, but still concentrated: one facility holds 87 of the exchange's 122 networks and nearly every 100 Gbps port, against 208 networks and 10,132 Gbps on the more distributed Johannesburg exchange	ADVANCED
Cell C 5G service	Did not exist	The third mobile operator's 5G service live for customers, claimed as the widest 5G coverage in the country because it roams on all of both larger operators' 5G sites at 2.6GHz and 3.5GHz rather than owning radio infrastructure	ADVANCED
Delivered data-centre load	~350MW (2024 benchmark)	~390MW (2025)	ADVANCED, MARGINAL
Draft Radio Frequency Spectrum and Fees Regulations amendments	Regulations of 2015 and 2010 unamended	Gazetted 2026-05-15; oral hearings 19-20 August 2026	ADVANCED
Equinix Cape Town land use	Baseline not held	Tribunal approval 2026-07-14	ADVANCED
High-demand spectrum auction	No date	The 2026 National Radio Frequency Plan targets 1,145 MHz more mid-band spectrum and over 17,250 MHz of mmWave against 794 MHz currently available - roughly 215% more high-demand spectrum cleared for release - but no auction has been scheduled, priced or gazetted	STALLED
IMT Roadmap 2026 and draft assignment plans	Baseline not held	Out for consultation	ADVANCED
LEO satellite licensing framework	Policy direction gazetted 2025-12-12	Direction rejected 2026-05; the minister publicly backs LEO entry while conceding licensing is the regulator's alone, and the 30% equity requirement stands	REGRESSED
National broadband map (DBSA)	None published	Launched 2026-03-31	ADVANCED
National Radio Frequency Plan 2026	Baseline not held	Gazetted 2026-07-24	ADVANCED
National wholesale 5G home-broadband network	Did not exist	Selling wholesale, 5G-core only, with the first retail ISP due live in September 2026	ADVANCED
Radio frequency spectrum fees regulations for satellite	Did not exist	Draft amendment under consultation, with the largest prospective entrant asking for flat per-licence fees and a ten-year minimum term	ADVANCED
SA Connect phase 2	Suspended pending rollover (2025-09)	Declared ended (2026-02)	CLOSED
Satellite market entry via section 13	Baseline not held	Amazon Leo-Herotel, 2026-07-15	ADVANCED
State Digital Infrastructure Company (network merger)	Road map due FY2025/26	Implementation moved to FY2028/29	REGRESSED
National cyber-security measurement	2024 CSIR surveys	Unchanged; no re-measurement	NO CHANGE
National CSIRT (Cybersecurity Hub)	BASELINE NOT HELD	Operating; no incident statistics published	Baseline not held
National Cybersecurity Policy Framework	BASELINE NOT HELD	In force; the instrument the national CSIRT rests on	Baseline not held

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
National GIS infrastructure database (rapid deployment reg. 7)	BASELINE NOT HELD	In development (2026-04-12)	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Data Storage

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Rights commission inquiry into data-centre expansion	Did not exist	The national human rights commission is scrutinising the country's data-centre expansion, with environmental groups warning that the infrastructure required to power the state's artificial-intelligence ambitions carries costs that have not been accounted for	ADVANCED
Teraco CT2, Cape Town	<i>Baseline not held</i>	+32MW to 50MW, 2025-11	ADVANCED
Johannesburg data-centre expansion	Not held	An international operator is scaling its Johannesburg facility to 24MW and holds a ZAR7.5bn South African expansion budget covering that site plus banked land in Johannesburg and Cape Town, with further build-out held pending demand	BASELINE NOT HELD

Technical Capacity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
National Integrated Cyber Infrastructure System	BASELINE NOT HELD	Operating; CHPC at maximum capacity, expansion required	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Cybersecurity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
FSCA enforcement against online financial harm	107 public warnings; R119.8m penalties (FY2024/25)	140 public warnings; R2.89bn penalties on 76 persons (FY2025/26)	ADVANCED
Ransomware attacker dwell time	117 days (2024)	18 days in 2025 on a digital-forensics firm's own incident statistics, with some intrusions running start to finish inside a day, attributed to ransomware-as-a-service, automated reconnaissance and AI-assisted attacks	ADVANCED
Departmental information security officer training programme	Not held	The public service and administration department is tendering to build a training programme for departmental information security officers across the public sector, to implement the directive on public service information security	BASELINE NOT HELD

Legislation and regulation

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Electronic Communications Amendment Bill	<i>Baseline not held</i>	Tabled by the Minister of Communications and Digital Technologies on 2026-04-20; it would empower the local-government minister to make a national standard by-law on rapid deployment of electronic communications networks, introduce a use-it-or-share-it principle for spectrum, regulate roaming and mobile virtual network operator services, improve the facilities-leasing framework, provide for wholesale pricing rules and strengthen competition regulation. The Bill was published with its explanatory summary and prior notice of introduction in Government Gazette No. 54548 of 20 April 2026, and introduced and referred to the Portfolio Committee on Communications and Digital Technologies on 22 April 2026. Written submissions were extended by one month on 2026-08-20, to 16:00 on 2026-09-21, superseding the 2026-08-21 deadline	ADVANCED

Strategies, plans and policies

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Draft National Policy on Data and Cloud	Draft	Draft; date of instrument disputed	NO CHANGE

SA Connect closed rather than delivered. Its in-year allocation [collapsed from an expected R1.1bn to R116m](#), money arrived only in January 2026 and equipment in the final month of the financial year; the [Budget Review recorded 6,343 government facilities and 32,055 hotspots, with R888.8m over the medium term to maintain 948 phase-one sites](#). The state network merger moved the other way: the FY2025/26 deliverable was a finalised road map, and the [annual performance plan tabled in March 2026](#) starts again with a preliminary report and implementation in FY2028/29.

On satellite, an instrument was issued and neutralised within five months. Starlink launched in its [27th African country in July 2026](#) without entering South Africa, while Amazon took the acquisition route the Act already allows.

Announced data-centre capacity and delivered capacity diverged. Pipeline announcements would take national load [above 1,200MW](#); delivered live load moved from roughly 350MW to 390MW, and the only completed facility of scale in the period was [Teraco's 50MW CT2](#). No national cyber-security measurement was repeated during the twelve months.

Digital public infrastructure

Data Exchange

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
MzansiXchange data exchange	One-year pilot launched 2025-10-09	Nine months in; extra capacity onboarding	ADVANCED, STALLING

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
SAHPRA VigiFlow serious-adverse-event e-reporting pilot	Did not exist	Pilot open by invitation; no duration or mandatory date published	ADVANCED
SARS-Malawi customs data exchange	Did not exist	Signed; no go-live date stated; the revenue service notified the updated arrangement for automatic exchange of customs information on 7 August 2026 and published a draft rule amendment with it	ADVANCED
Digital VAT model	Not held	Out to consultation: the revenue service proposes a five-corner digital VAT model of electronic invoicing, an interoperability framework and electronic reporting, moving toward VAT auto-assessment, with a phased rollout from 2026/27 and stakeholder feedback due 16 October 2026	BASELINE NOT HELD
One-stop border posts and digitised border systems	BASELINE NOT HELD	Named a chairship priority for the regional bloc, tied to the corridor trip monitoring system integrating transport, immigration and customs data, to online permitting and operator accreditation, to the country's electronic visa and travel authorisation, and to a proposed regional tourism visa, with progress to be measured in border-crossing times reduced rather than agreements signed	Baseline not held

Digital Identity and CRVS

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Digital driving licence	Promised for 2026	Nearest dated milestone 2027-03	STALLED
Draft Identification Regulations amendments	Did not exist	Gazetted 2026-05-04 and the comment period closed on 2026-06-06. A research organisation's submission on the closing day asked the department to suspend the regulations pending a published Digital Identity Policy, an enacted National Identification and Registration Bill and demonstrated compliance with the data-protection Act, on the ground that they create a biometric enrolment, trusted-entity accreditation and real-time verification system with no formal role for the Information Regulator	ADVANCED
Electronic travel authorisation	Pilot from 2025-10	Launched by the president at OR Tambo and live at four airports – OR Tambo, Cape Town, King Shaka and Lanseria – from 2026-08-12, with 6,126 fraudulent applications rejected, put at 2.8% of pilot submissions, and full visa-type rollout targeted by end-2026	ADVANCED
National digital identity (credential and wallet)	"Before the 2029 elections" (2025-12)	Hosting 2027-03-31; credentials 2027/28	STALLED

Digital Payments and Fintech

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Capitec-Walletdoc merger conditions	Did not exist	Behavioural conditions agreed; Tribunal had not ruled at 2026-08-06	ADVANCED
Cashless municipal service offices, Cape Town	Pilot at three offices	Six offices from 1 September 2026, cash no longer accepted at the counter	ADVANCED
CIPS participation (Standard Bank)	No African bank held CIPS direct-participant status	Standard Bank live as the first African bank offering CIPS transactions; RMB the settlement currency	ADVANCED

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Commercial bank technology spending	None published	One of the large banks put technology spending at R8.78bn in the first half of 2026, up 7%, against digitally active customers up 14%, with a further R200m software impairment following a R2.4bn write-down in 2025; its cost-to-income ratio kept rising through the migration, across a 17-country, 13.4-million-customer footprint	ADVANCED
Renminbi Clearing Bank of Africa	Did not exist; CIPS participation only (live 2025-11-20)	Standard Bank and ICBC jointly authorised as RMB clearing bank for Africa, with operational capacity in the 19 African countries where Standard Bank Group operates	ADVANCED
ZARU rand-backed stablecoin	Did not exist	Listed on Luno Global 2026-08-07, quoted against USDT and USDC; a merchant payments provider integrated the token into its infrastructure on 19 August, letting its commerce partners make and receive payments in it	ADVANCED
Payments Ecosystem Modernisation credential and wallet	BASILINE NOT HELD	In development (2026-07-31)	Baseline not held
Retail central bank digital currency	BASILINE NOT HELD	Planned, not proceeding (2026-07-02)	Baseline not held

Registries (population, land, address, etc.)

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Blocked identity numbers	384,189 (2025-12)	377,060	STALLED
Intelligent Population Register	BASILINE NOT HELD	In development (2026-07-07)	Baseline not held
National Population Register	BASILINE NOT HELD	Implemented (2026-07-29)	Baseline not held
Uncollected identity documents	Baseline not held	360,000 uncollected at Home Affairs offices (2026-07-31)	BASILINE NOT HELD

Sectoral management information systems (HMIS, EMIS, etc.)

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
NSFAS student funding system	Board dissolved 2024 over IT-system failures	Under administration; ICT named the largest operational risk	REGRESSED
National Digital Health Strategy 2019-2024	Term already expired	No successor strategy held	NO CHANGE

Other GovTech and e-Gov

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Batho Pele AI chatbot	Did not exist	DPSA-Meta-Juicetel partnership built on Meta's Llama models, providing policy, circular and legislation lookups to citizens and public servants; nine official languages targeted; explicitly decision-support only, with no decision-making authority	ADVANCED

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Home Affairs system downtime	35,426 hours of nationwide system downtime (2024/25)	13,867 hours in 2025/26, a 61% reduction, with provincial gains ranging from 79% in the Free State to 41% in North West; the population register's own downtime fell from 14,720 to 11,479 hours, a 22% improvement. The department attributes it to the state IT agency moving from a bronze to a silver service level, 226 links migrated to fibre, 182 offices moved to a web service manager and 439 offices running on the identification system	ADVANCED
IEC digital voter registration (WhatsApp and online portal)	Online portal only	1.7m registration transactions over the final weekend; 291,016 first-time registrations	ADVANCED
MyMzansi single citizen application	Prototype; public access H1 2026	Production-ready pilot; stable platform 2026-09	ADVANCED, SLIPPED
National payment code standard (QR+)	Did not exist	v1.2, eight-bank test cohort	ADVANCED
PayInc and the SARB stake	50% acquired 2025-10	Bank-owned utility; non-bank shareholding ruled out (2026-07-31)	ADVANCED
PayShap	Baseline not held	905m transactions by 2026-05	ADVANCED
Smart ID and bank-branch channel	30 branches, five banks (2025-08)	Smart identity services running at participating bank branches — 410 live as at 13 August 2026, with 574,371 applications processed through banks — against a formal departmental target of at least 200 more and a stated possibility of 750 branches during 2026/27; the department also commits to modernising 75 of the 145 remaining unmodernised local offices this financial year	ADVANCED
Smart IDs issued, calendar year	Baseline not held	4,002,964 in 2025, +17%	ADVANCED
VAT modernisation consultation paper	Did not exist	The revenue service released a VAT Modernisation Consultation Paper proposing a digital VAT model combining electronic invoicing, an interoperability framework and electronic reporting, aimed at moving VAT administration off manual processes and retrospective verification and into the systems businesses already run; it follows a 2023 discussion paper and is stated as building blocks rather than a decided design	ADVANCED
Western Cape Infrastructure Virtual Platform (EVE AI agent)	Did not exist	Automatically evaluates projects against Treasury rules and ISO 9001 via AI agent EVE; evaluated pipeline of 52 projects worth R132bn, 11 worth over R20bn to be released to market; MoUs signed with Infrastructure South Africa, IFISA, EDC South Africa and UCT	ADVANCED
Gauteng online school admissions	In operation since 2016	2027 intake opened 2026-08-05	NO CHANGE
National Health Insurance information architecture	In force since 2022-10-21	In force; no implementation measurement held, with the scheme it underpins in Phase 2 and its enabling Act under constitutional challenge	NO CHANGE
Courts digitisation project	Not held	Records storage has been outsourced to a private contractor since 2021 across three provinces; on 13 August 2026 the justice minister referred the project to the special investigating unit and the police priority crimes unit after the contractor denied the department access to its own records at the Master of the High Court in Pretoria	BASELINE NOT HELD
Digital matric certificate	BASELINE NOT HELD	Piloting (2026-08-03)	Baseline not held
Minimum Interoperability Standards and GWEA	BASELINE NOT HELD	In development (2026-07-31)	Baseline not held
Online Verification Service	BASELINE NOT HELD	Implemented (undated)	Baseline not held

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Student-aid scheme systems integration	BASELINE NOT HELD	The Public Protector found the scheme's systems insufficiently integrated with the home affairs, social security and revenue data sources it needs to verify students, and directed a digital modernisation and systems-integration plan within 30 days covering institutional integration, verification interfaces, fraud controls and cyber security, elimination of duplicate applications and manual workarounds, student-facing case tracking and costed milestones	<i>Baseline not held</i>
Western Cape funding-matching platform for small business	BASELINE NOT HELD	Free access for micro, small and medium enterprises in the province to a matching platform covering over 300 funders and 600 finance products	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Legislation and regulation

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
National Identification and Registration Bill	BASELINE NOT HELD	Still before Parliament	<i>Baseline not held</i>

The digital identity schedule slipped at every stated milestone. A deadline of April 2025 for cabinet approval of the legal framework was missed; the roadmap milestone of a functional digital identity by the end of the 2025 financial year was missed; the President told Parliament on 12 February 2026 that digital identity and the digital driving licence would [launch during 2026](#); and the department's own plan, tabled six weeks later, [put hosting at 31 March 2027 and operation at 2027/28](#). The draft regulations were nonetheless made and consulted on within the period, and an objection that they may be ultra vires of the Identification Act remains unanswered.

Blocked identity numbers fell by 7,129 in roughly seven months, from 384,189 to [377,060](#), against 702,267 at judgment and a court deadline now running to March 2027. MyMzansi's first public access moved from March 2026 to September 2026. MzansiXchange, launched as a one-year pilot in October 2025, was [nine months in and onboarding further technical capacity](#) at the period's end, with no date set for the rollout decision the pilot was to trigger. Payments moved fastest: PayShap went from 461m cumulative transactions in March 2026 to [905m by May](#), and the central bank became co-owner of the rail in October 2025.

Governance and regulation

Other GovTech and e-Gov

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Digital Transformation of Government Roadmap	BASELINE NOT HELD	Implemented (2025-04-03)	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Legislation and regulation

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Capital Flow Management Regulations and Crypto Asset Manual	Did not exist	Both in draft; manual comments to end-September 2026; the Treasury and the central bank published a draft crypto asset manual for cross-border activities for comment to 30 September 2026, setting authorisation and reporting rules for crypto asset service providers and defining cross-border crypto flows	ADVANCED
Copyright Amendment Bill	Baseline not held	Constitutional Court ruling 2026-06	ADVANCED
Draft Electoral Code of Conduct on Countering Disinformation	Did not exist	A draft code published by the Electoral Commission under section 88 of the Local Government: Municipal Electoral Act 27 of 2000 for the local government elections, out for written comment to 22 July 2026. It carries no commencement date and no standalone sanction: paragraph 14 makes a contravention a breach sanctionable under the Act	ADVANCED
End-user and Subscriber Service Charter Amendment Regulations	In consultation	Gazetted 2026-01-23; under review application	ADVANCED, LITIGATED
Operation Vulindlela reporting	80% of initiatives on track (2026-04)	"Uneven and slower than anticipated"	REGRESSED
POPIA enforcement notices	None held	Three notices, May–June 2026	ADVANCED
SADC real-time settlement	Rand only since 2013	Kwanza added 2026-07-27	ADVANCED
Breach notification rate	~284 per month (Apr–Nov 2025)	~263 per month (Q1 2026)	NO CHANGE
National Open Science Policy	BASELINE NOT HELD	Implemented (undated)	Baseline not held

Strategies, plans and policies

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Cost to Communicate Roadmap	Did not exist; no successor instrument after the 2019 Data Services Market Inquiry	Study out to tender; no roadmap published	ADVANCED
ICT indicators and scenario-modelling system to 2050	BASELINE NOT HELD	Tendered by the communications department to steer the digital economy to 2050, framed against the National Digital Transformation Roadmap, the Presidential Commission on the Fourth Industrial Revolution and the Digital Economy Masterplan; no award, value or delivery date published	Baseline not held
Mega infrastructure project monitoring dashboard	Not held	A joint push by the Presidency and the planning and evaluation department to fast-track a digital dashboard monitoring mega infrastructure projects, put before the parliamentary committee on the Presidency alongside a wider review of progress against the state-of-the-nation commitments	BASELINE NOT HELD
Operation Vulindlela Phase II	BASELINE NOT HELD	Implemented (2026-07-31)	Baseline not held

Standards

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
ICT and Media Regulators Forum	BASELINE NOT HELD	Implemented (2026-07-31)	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Data protection

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Protection of Personal Information Act and Information Regulator	<i>Baseline not held</i>	The regulator has taken its challenge to newspaper publication of school-leaving results to the Supreme Court of Appeal after losing three bids in the high court, arguing the education department is obliged to release results directly to learners and has no contract or legal basis for press publication; it also told a webinar on 18 August that it has no capability to test external systems for privacy compliance before launch and is working with the justice department to amend the Act to cover artificial intelligence and privacy by design	ADVANCED
Consumer Protection Act direct-marketing opt-out registry	BASELINE NOT HELD	In development (2026-04-20)	<i>Baseline not held</i>
Mandatory breach reporting e-portal	BASELINE NOT HELD	Implemented (2025-04-15)	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Public debate and participation in policymaking

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Policy brief on information integrity and human rights	BASELINE NOT HELD	Published by the rights commission, and launched with a deputy justice minister's statement that government should not become the custodian of truth on disinformation while the information environment should not be left to private platforms' algorithms, grounded in sections 16, 19 and 32 of the Constitution	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Enforcement began during the period. The Information Regulator issued its [first 2026 enforcement notice in May](#), a [precedent-setting access-to-information notice against a mining company in June](#), and a third treating a misdirected email as a reportable breach — while the monthly breach-notification rate stayed broadly flat and the statutory maximum penalty remained R10m.

Operation Vulindlela's own reporting changed within the period: a briefing in April 2026 put [80% of digital transformation initiatives on track](#) with 20% complete; the July report replaces that quantified claim with a qualitative statement that progress has been uneven. No later percentage is on record.

Artificial intelligence and the technology sector

Legislation and regulation

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Conduct of Financial Institutions Bill	BASELINE NOT HELD	In development (2026-01-30)	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Strategies, plans and policies

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
National AI policy	Cabinet March 2026, finalise FY2026/27 (as at 2026-02)	No gazetted policy; cabinet Nov 2026 or Jan 2027	REGRESSED

Standards

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Crypto-asset service provider licensing	300 licences (2025-12-31)	Licensing of centralised crypto-asset service providers is in force, but the regulator states the model has no purchase on decentralised finance - protocols with no company, board or natural person to hold accountable - and plans to attach obligations elsewhere; no instrument for DeFi is published	NO CHANGE
AI-in-finance regulatory framework	BASELINE NOT HELD	Planned (2026-07-16)	<i>Baseline not held</i>

AI

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Appeal on algorithmic eligibility verification for the SRD grant	None published	The state is appealing a Pretoria High Court judgment of 23 January 2025 that held several regulations governing the Social Relief of Distress grant unconstitutional and invalid, on a scheme administered online only and screened by an algorithmic verification system that excluded applicants it read as earning above R624.00; the court found the automation unfairly excluded otherwise eligible applicants. An artificial-intelligence governance organisation, represented by a university legal centre, was admitted as a friend of the court in the appeal, which is set down for hearing on 25 August 2026	ADVANCED
Automated selection at SARS	<i>Baseline not held</i>	100% of verifications, 88.41% of complex audits	ADVANCED
Proposed AI regulatory institutions	Seven bodies proposed	Under reconsideration; committee opposed	REGRESSED
SAHPRA AI/ML medical-device requirements	Did not exist	Issued 2025-09-26; product registration not commenced	ADVANCED
Start-up funding, South Africa	Led Africa on equity and deal count, CY2025	Fourth at \$83m, H1 2026	REGRESSED

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Customer-facing AI assistant at a major bank	Baseline not held	An agentic artificial-intelligence chatbot handling over 100,000 queries a month from about 1.6 million users in the first half of 2026, alongside 30,000 employees a month on a vendor productivity assistant, more than 3,800 staff-built automation agents in production and over 1,400 developers on AI-assisted coding tools	BASELINE NOT HELD
Enterprise AI adoption at a major bank	Not held	More than 39,000 staff, 72% of the workforce, reported as active generative-artificial-intelligence users on a multi-model enterprise platform hosted on a foreign cloud provider, with relationship management, servicing, payments and lending named as the four priority areas	BASELINE NOT HELD
Machine-learning screening of travellers for fraud	BASELINE NOT HELD	Stated intention to screen travellers for fraud using machine learning; no system, procurement, legal basis, accuracy measure or appeal route is published	<i>Baseline not held</i>
SARS Modernisation 3.0	BASELINE NOT HELD	In development (2026-07-23)	<i>Baseline not held</i>

ICT Industry

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Mobile virtual network operator subscriptions	Baseline not held	About 4.4 million active MVNO SIMs at end-2025 on an analyst count, up about 43% year on year and forecast to reach 14.4 million by 2030; the fourth-largest of the five mobile operators reported 5.7 million MVNO subscribers carried on its own wholesale platform for the 12 months to 2026-05-31, which it put at an estimated 80-85% share of the market	ADVANCED
B-BBEE ICT Sector Council	Baseline not held	The communications minister replaced the council's chairperson and appointed an interim chair for six months after a departmental investigation found the council dysfunctional; the investigation report is not published, and no remedial plan, terms of reference for the interim period or date for a permanent appointment is stated	BASELINE NOT HELD
Informal-retail transaction data product	BASELINE NOT HELD	A listed payments company sells near-real-time item-level intelligence on the informal retail economy, drawn from a point-of-sale network of over 90,000 spaza shops and taverns and 10,500 checkouts, to consumer-goods brands, wholesalers and financiers	<i>Baseline not held</i>

The AI policy changed kind as well as date. A timeline reported in February 2026 had cabinet consideration in March and finalisation within FY2026/27; the draft was published on 2 April, withdrawn later that month, a review panel was appointed on 14 May, and the department stated on 29 July that the replacement [will issue guidelines rather than prescribe rules](#). Automated decision-making expanded through the same period without a governing framework.

Funding reversed within the period. South Africa raised [\\$335.9m across 42 ventures in calendar 2025](#) on a measure its publisher describes as a minimum floor, leading the continent; in the first half of 2026 it [ranked fourth at \\$83m](#) as continental deal count fell 42% year on year.

Inclusion and capacity

Access to services

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Bank-account means test across eight grants	Appeal opposed 2026-01-28	Undecided; SCA hearing 2026-08-25	STALLED
MICT SETA	Baseline not held	Referred for assessment 2026-07-21	REGRESSED
Postbank Black Card migration	463,836 active gold cards (2026-04-29)	172,146 replaced by 2026-07-28; 264,263 outstanding	ADVANCED
SASSA biometric verification against Home Affairs	42,000 in first two weeks (2025-09)	997,379 of 19.05m recipients (2026-03)	ADVANCED, PARTIAL
SASSA grant reviews	Biometric enrolment live 2025-09-01	420,000 flagged; ~160,000 incomplete	ADVANCED IN SCOPE, REGRESSED IN ACCESS
SITA performance	Baseline not held	R2.07bn irregular over four years	REGRESSED
Smartphone excise removal	Removed April 2025	1.1m additional entry-level units, against a continental average selling price up \$41 to \$202 and sub-\$100 shipments down 34% year on year in Q2 2026	ADVANCED, OFFSET BY RISING DEVICE PRICES
DCDT expenditure	Baseline not held	R3.61bn of R3.74bn spent, FY2025/26	NO CHANGE
Bank self-service kiosk network	Baseline not held	581 self-service kiosks handling more than half a million transactions a month across over 60 banking services, through which almost 70% of instant-issued debit cards are dispensed and 56% of kiosk-issued cards go to entry-level clients; mall-based zones pairing kiosks with consultant support enter pilot at a Johannesburg mall in late August 2026, with wider deployment flagged for the mid- to long term	BASELINE NOT HELD
Disability-inclusive data cooperation with China	Not held	A seven-point plan agreed to deepen cooperation on disability-inclusive data, universal design and artificial-intelligence-enabled assistive technology, anchored in a proposed disability centre of excellence working with the national statistics office	BASELINE NOT HELD

Training and skills

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
National Digital and Future Skills Strategy 2020	2020 strategy in force	Under review; no replacement	STALLED
Vendor digital-skills programme in Northern Cape schools	Did not exist	A networking vendor's academy and a private group agreed with the provincial education department to take networking, cyber security and artificial-intelligence courses into 235 schools, as extracurricular classes for grades 10 to 12 beginning February 2027, inside a global skills-to-jobs programme the vendor states has trained more than 600,000 South Africans	ADVANCED

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Digital-skills pipeline from school to employment	Baseline not held	Constrained at both ends and structurally so: employers report about 7 per cent of ICT and engineering posts unfilled, with software developers (380), network engineers (285) and ICT security specialists (130) the hardest-to-fill roles, while 44.8 per cent of online vacancy postings ask for transversal digital skills, 30.9 per cent for basic ICT skills and 26.4 per cent for advanced ones; employers attribute the gap 26 per cent to shortfalls in basic-level training, 24 per cent to graduate pipeline throughput and 21 per cent to the pace of technological change (2026-06)	BASELINE NOT HELD
National Competency Framework	BASELINE NOT HELD	In development (2026-07-23)	Baseline not held

Research institutions

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Standing in digital-privacy research	Baseline not held	18th worldwide and the only African country in the top 20 for digital-privacy research output, on a 4,760-article review of 2005-2025	BASELINE NOT HELD

Grant verification widened during the period. Biometric enrolment began on 1 September 2025 and had reached 997,379 of 19.05m recipients by March 2026, about 5%; 420,000 grants were flagged during 2025/26 and roughly 160,000 beneficiaries did not complete the review, with child-grant recipients reporting months without payment. The litigation that would settle the mechanism was neither implemented nor decided within the twelve months.

At the State Information Technology Agency, a Public Service Commission investigation reported R2.07bn of irregular expenditure across four audited years and annual performance plan achievement of 42.86% in FY2024/25; the 30-day deadline for a recovery plan expired within the period, and no plan is recorded.

Finance

New investments

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-23	MOVEMENT
Science and Technology Accelerator-Systems, Southern Africa	Baseline not held	Up to GBP2.5m over three years to March 2030, of which up to GBP400,000 for 2026/27, covering artificial intelligence and emerging technologies and digital access alongside climate, energy, health and space; South Africa the primary focus, Zimbabwe and Zambia the first year's	BASELINE NOT HELD

This section holds one row and it opened at the very end of the period, so there is no movement to report over the twelve months — only an arrival. On 11 August the United Kingdom opened expressions of interest for a Southern Africa science and technology accelerator worth up to GBP2.5m to March 2030, with South Africa its primary focus. No delivery consortium has been chosen, so the programme has a ceiling and a subject matter and nothing else yet. The rest of South Africa's digital financing sits outside this ledger, in the domestic budget lines and private data-centre capital recorded elsewhere in this report.

Where the record is thin

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT	LAST PROBED
Data-centre incentive instrument (SEZ, depreciation, grid priority)	—	not yet probed
Education management information systems	—	not yet probed
Electronic death registration system	—	not yet probed
Cross-border transfer adequacy determinations	—	not yet probed
Malabo Convention ratification position	—	not yet probed
AfCFTA Digital Trade Protocol domestication	—	not yet probed
Rules governing state automated decision-making	—	not yet probed
AI incident or assurance register	—	not yet probed
Digital inclusion strategy instrument	—	not yet probed
National digital literacy measurement	—	not yet probed
Municipal ICT expenditure data	—	not yet probed
Innovation spectrum, lower 6GHz	The gazette notice releasing lower-6 GHz innovation spectrum, or an ICASA decision or licence record naming it.	2026-08-14
District Health Information System	A National Department of Health statement, annual report or tender record for the District Health Information System, including the hosting arrangement put out to tender in 2026-07.	2026-08-14
Non-bank payment service provider licensing	The National Payment System Act amendment bill or a SARB directive establishing a licensing regime for non-bank payment service providers.	2026-08-14
SAMOS real-time gross settlement	A South African Reserve Bank statement, annual report or system document on SAMOS, which the base carries no source for at any date.	2026-08-14
Cybercrimes Act	The gazetted Cybercrimes Act 19 of 2020 with its commencement proclamation, or a prosecution or enforcement record under it.	2026-08-14
Information Regulator appropriation	The Information Regulator's annual report or the Justice vote's appropriation line naming its allocation.	2026-08-14
Expert review panel	The ministerial notice or departmental statement appointing the expert review panel and naming its members and terms of reference.	2026-08-14
Prudential Authority AI and cloud supervision standards	A Prudential Authority directive, guidance note or consultation paper on artificial-intelligence and cloud supervision standards.	2026-08-14
Sector-level AI strategies	A departmental or sector-regulator statement naming a sector-level artificial-intelligence strategy and its status.	2026-08-14
Analogue television switch-off date	a gazetted or ministerially announced switch-off date, or a departmental statement of the criteria and household threshold that would set one	2026-08-14
Institutional policy on artificial intelligence in higher education	a sector instrument from the higher education department or the quality council, or a published institutional policy on artificial intelligence in teaching and assessment at a named university	2026-08-17
Public participation in data-centre approvals	A published public-participation procedure for data-centre siting or approval, or a commission or authority response to the coalition's submission.	2026-08-11

Seventeen of the fifty-three rows above carry *Baseline not held* at the opening date. Almost all fall in the same five months. The base holds no South African domestic payments source published between August and December 2025, so PayShap volumes, the central bank's October 2025 acquisition of half the payment company, the payment code standard and the social grant card migration are all reconstructed from January 2026 onward. The electronic travel authorisation launched in October 2025 and is first recorded in a February 2026 secondary source. The licensing inquiry that has blocked satellite network licences since August 2025 has no primary document on file at all. Without August to December 2025, this twelve-month comparison is in several places a seven-month one.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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Figures are dated because most are time-varying: a figure carries the date it was true, not the date you are reading it. Where the base holds no reliable statement, the document says **Not held** rather than leaving a silence — those are counted, and listed at the end.

This is a dated edition and is not revised after publication. If a figure here has moved, the current edition will say so.